



October 2, 2013

Chair Jon Ulrich and Executive Committee
Highway 169 Corridor Coalition
14043 Walters Way
Savage, MN 55378

RE: Request for Consideration of Support for the Highway 169/CSAH 3 Grade Separation and Access Project

Dear Chair Ulrich and Executive Committee:

The City of Belle Plaine respectfully requests consideration of the inclusion of the TH 169/CSAH 3 Grade Separation and Access Project to the Highway 169 Corridor Coalition Corridors of Commerce project list.

The City of Belle Plaine, Scott County, MnDOT and surrounding townships have been working together for over a decade on a vision for TH169 through the Belle Plaine area. Before 2004, there were seven at-grade access points along TH 169 in the City. Since that time, an interchange has been constructed at TH 25/TH 169 and all remaining at-grade intersections closed, except for CSAH 3. Interim improvements were completed at CSAH 3 in 2008 to reduce conflicts but this also eliminated regional and local crossing traffic and decreased access for land uses to the regional roadway system. The City of Belle Plaine was informed the CSAH 3/TH 169 intersection changes were intended to be an interim solution to address safety concerns until project partners could secure funding to complete the agreed upon vision of a CSAH 3 overpass with interim right-turn access to TH 169.

In support of the CSAH 3/TH 169 vision MnDOT, Scott County and the City of Belle Plaine agreed upon in 2010, the City has continued to move forward in developing frontage road connections to serve the future overpass and access improvements. Over \$2.5 million federal and local dollars has been spent since 2008 to support the CSAH 3 overpass and interim right-turn access.

The CSAH 3 Project would be a good fit for the Corridors of Commerce program since the project need is consistent with the program's goal to grow the economy. The CSAH 3 Project is needed to reestablish the connection of CSAH 3 across TH 169 for both regional freight traffic and the local community/economy. CSAH 3 serves an important north/south route for freight between Le Sueur County, Scott County and the TH 25 Minnesota River crossing. Much of this freight on CSAH 3 desires to cross CSAH 3 at TH 169 to travel through Belle Plaine and access the TH 25 Minnesota River crossing (a vital crossing that has remained open even during flooding events over the past decade). The current disconnect of CSAH 3 at TH 169 is inefficient for freight traffic that desires to make this river crossing connection. In addition, the elimination of several access points to TH 169 and the connection between the two sides of the community have left the business community significantly severed and the future business growth area of the community unattractive. An important factor in sustaining businesses that remain in Belle Plaine, while also attracting new business to the area, is the CSAH 3 Project which will complete the City's transportation system.

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A tremendous level of local and regional support exists for this project and it is ready to proceed with construction if the remaining gap in funding can be found. In addition, a Level II MnDOT Staff Approved Layout has been developed for this project and most of the right-of-way has already been secured. Scott County has committed \$700,000 towards this project in the Scott County 2013-2022 Transportation Improvement Program and the City has also identified funding to make this project a reality.

In conclusion, the CSAH 3/TH 169 Project is a significant project for both the local and regional economy. This project will complete the overall vision for TH 169 in Belle Plaine to achieve the mobility and safety objectives identified by the project partners. This project puts the finishing touches on the implementation of over a decade of planning in this region that has removed a traffic signal from TH 169, removed over 224 conflict points on TH 169 and reduced crashes by removing all at-grade left-turn conflicts.

We request your help to support the TH 169/CSAH 3 Grade Separation and Access Project to the Highway 169 Corridor Coalition's Corridors of Commerce project list.

Sincerely,



Michael Pingalore
Mayor of Belle Plaine

c: Belle Plaine City Council
Scott County Administrator Gary Shelton
Scott County Deputy Administrator Lezlie Vermillion
Scott County Commissioner Joe Wagner
MnDOT Metro Dist. Dir. of Planning, Prog. Management & Transit Pat Bursaw
Executive Committee